

POLI110 Week 3 Types of Claims:

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1 Introduction

This note distills the typology from our Week 3 slides and uses it to systematically review the claims in the assigned reading.¹ Our goals are: (i) to separate value-laden positions from empirical assertions; (ii) to distinguish patterns from effects; and (iii) to map each claim to a research design that could adjudicate it.

2 Conceptual framework

We adopt the course typology:

- **Normative** express value judgments (e.g., desirable ends or fairness criteria).
- **Prescriptive** recommend actions (*should/should not*); they usually embed both values and factual premises.
- **Descriptive** state how the world is/was; correlations and factual comparisons fit here.
- **Causal** assert that a change in X would change Y (effects of causes / causes of effects), often implying a counterfactual comparison.

3 Source material and scope

We analyze Bronner (2012), which juxtaposes cross-state policy differences, time trends, and scholarly views on guns and violence. We treat *quoted statements* and *authorial paraphrases of research* as claims requiring classification. Where a statement implies a mechanism or counterfactual, we classify it as CAUSAL; where it states patterns or institutions without an effect language, we classify it as DESCRIPTIVE; explicit *should*-type positions are NORMATIVE/PRESCRIPTIVE.²

4 Survey of the article's claims

Descriptive (Descriptive)

- D1. The suspect purchased multiple firearms and 6,000 rounds of ammunition after easily obtaining a permit because he had no criminal record. (DESCRIPTIVE)
- D2. California and Massachusetts ban most assault rifles and large-capacity magazines; a federal ban existed from 1994 to 2004. (DESCRIPTIVE)
- D3. Before 1986, ammunition could not legally be sent by mail. (DESCRIPTIVE)
- D4. States with the strictest gun laws (HI, MA, NJ, NY) have among the lowest gun-death rates, while the most lenient states (AL, AK, LA, MS) have among the highest; overall homicide fell despite fewer gun-control laws than 20 years ago. (DESCRIPTIVE)
- D5. Scholars disagree over whether tighter laws reduce killing or have no effect. (DESCRIPTIVE)
- D6. New York and Massachusetts had lower violence before gun-control laws were enacted. (DESCRIPTIVE)
- D7. Laws are often weakly enforced and riddled with loopholes; many guns are traded outside the regulated system, complicating evaluation. (DESCRIPTIVE)

¹Slides: *Tutorial 2: Types of Claims* (Week 3). Reading: Ethan Bronner, "Other States, and Other Times, Would Have Posed Obstacles for Gunman" (*New York Times*, July 24, 2012)

²All passages and paraphrases referenced in Sections 4-?? are drawn from the assigned article.

Causal (Causal)

- C1. *Counterfactual* claim: in a different state or earlier time, the gunman would have faced more obstacles. (CAUSAL)
- C2. Application processes with police screening operate as an additional filter that *weeds out* high-risk applicants. (CAUSAL)
- C3. Gun availability *does not* raise overall violent-crime volume but *converts* assaults into murders (intensifies lethality). (CAUSAL)
- C4. Reverse-causality hypothesis: higher homicide rates lead residents to acquire more guns; more guns *do not* raise homicide. (CAUSAL)
- C5. The Brady Law produced *virtually no reduction* in homicide post-enactment (policy effect: null). (CAUSAL)
- C6. Substitution/avoidance: blocking a specific model may not bind if similar models remain legal. (CAUSAL)
- C7. Accountability—strong dealer regulation and permit-to-purchase—*reduces diversion* of guns to criminals and curbs cross-state exports of crime guns. (CAUSAL)

Normative/Prescriptive (Normative/Prescriptive)

- N1. Whether police *should* be empowered to decide who may own guns (skepticism about discretionary screening). (NORMATIVE/PRESCRIPTIVE)
- N2. Whether the federal government *should* renew bans or expand accountability regimes. (NORMATIVE/PRESCRIPTIVE)

Appendix A: Classified claims (detail)

Table A.1: Descriptive Claims

Claim	Rationale	Slide link
"He bought permits and weapons easily because he lacked a record."	Factual sequence; no effect verb.	Descriptive
"CA/MA ban most assault rifles; federal ban 1994–2004."	Institutional/time facts.	Descriptive
"Before 1986, ammunition could not be mailed legally."	Legal time change.	Descriptive
"NJ requires application to police; behavior might have raised concern."	Process description; effect implied but not claimed.	Descriptive
"Scholars assert either tighter laws reduce killing or do nothing."	Describes disagreement, not an effect.	Descriptive
"Ownership/restrictions fell; homicide rose and fell; today fewer laws, homicide down."	Trends juxtaposed; no causal verb.	Descriptive (correlation)
"Strict-law states have among the lowest gun-death rates; lenient states among the highest."	Cross-state association.	Descriptive/correlation
"Whether any causal relationship exists remains disputed."	Meta-claim about uncertainty.	Descriptive
"More guns, more homicide (literature review)."	Summarizes associations across units.	Descriptive
"NY/MA were less violent before gun laws."	Baseline difference (confounding).	Descriptive → ID risk
"Many guns transact outside the system; evaluation is difficult."	Coverage/measurement limits.	Descriptive
"Poor enforcement + loopholes confound effectiveness assessments."	Implementation challenges.	Descriptive

Table A.2: Causal Claims

Claim	Rationale	Slide link
"If the gunman had acted in a different state or earlier time, he would have faced more obstacles."	Counterfactual implies policy affects access.	Causal/counterfactual
"Screening is another filter to weed out risks."	Mechanism: screening reduces approvals among high-risk.	Causal (mechanism)
"Availability converts assaults into murders; not more crime overall."	Specifies severity margin as effect.	Causal (mechanism)
"Guns do not bring murder; murder brings guns."	Reverse-causality hypothesis.	Causal (competing)
"Brady Law: virtually no reduction in homicide."	Policy-effect (null) claim.	Causal
"Blocking model X leaves close substitutes available."	Substitution attenuates treatment.	Causal (behavioral response)
"Accountability: stronger dealer rules + permits reduce diversion and interstate exports."	Mechanism: accountability ↓ illegal flow.	Causal (mechanism)

Table A.3: Normative/Prescriptive Claims

Claim	Rationale	Slide link
"Police should not decide who can own a gun."	Value-laden institutional stance.	Normative/Prescriptive
Federal renewal of bans or accountability regimes (implied)	Policy recommendation.	Normative/Prescriptive